

Claude Code for Economic Research

A Practical Introduction

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What → How → Wisdom

What is Claude Code?
Terminal vs. App

Tools, CLAUDE.md,
skills & agents

Privacy, best practices,
department discussion

What Is Claude Code?

Not a chatbot — an agent that acts

Claude Code is an agent that lives inside your project

An **agentic coding tool** by Anthropic that lives in your terminal (or browser). It reads, writes, searches, and executes code **autonomously** on your machine.

Regular chatbot

- ✗ Sees only what you paste
- ✗ Cannot run your code
- ✗ Forgets project structure
- ✗ You do all the work

Claude Code

- ✓ Reads your entire project
- ✓ Runs Stata, R, Python, $\text{\LaTeX}$
- ✓ Understands project context
- ✓ Works while you think

Same model. Different mode. One converses. The other *acts*.

Three tasks that take hours now take minutes

Data cleaning

“Read
survey_raw.dta, drop
obs where price < 0,
save as
survey_clean.dta”

Automate repetitive data

work

Regressions

“Run a diff-in-diff with
reghdfe, cluster at
county, export table”
Debug and refactor faster

Writing

“Turn my notes into a
Beamer deck with
figures from
results.Rda”
Draft to compiled PDF

Works with any language: Stata, R, Python, $\text{\LaTeX}$...

How to Use It

Two interfaces, one engine

Two interfaces, same engine — terminal or browser

Terminal (CLI)

```
npm install -g  
@anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Type claude in your project folder.

Keyboard-driven, fast, scriptable.

Best for: power users, automation.

Browser (claude.ai Code mode)

No installation needed.

Visual interface, drag-and-drop files.

Same tools, same file access.

Best for: getting started, visual work-flows.

Both read your CLAUDE.md. Both act on your files. Pick whichever fits.

Built-in Tools

Ten tools, but you'll use three daily

Ten built-in tools, but you'll use three daily

Read / Write / Edit

file I/O

Bash

run any command

Grep / Glob

search everything

Agent

Skill

WebSearch

WebFetch

Task / Plan

orchestration & discovery — loaded on demand

Skills and agents just control *how* these tools are used.

Setting Up Claude

Write it once, never repeat yourself

CLAUDE.md is your standing instructions — loaded every session

CLAUDE.md tells Claude **who you are**, **how to behave**, and **what rules to follow**.

```
## Who I Am
PhD candidate in economics.  Tools:  Stata, LaTeX, R.

## Critical Rules
1.  NEVER delete data files
2.  NEVER delete program files
3.  Raw data is sacred --- read only

## Active Projects
My JMP          1-JM.Paper/          Empirical analysis
Side Project    2-Side.Project/      Data preparation
```

30 minutes upfront saves hours of repeated instructions. Have Claude help you write it.

A good CLAUDE.md has three layers

Who I am — role, tools, research context

identity

My rules — never delete data, coding conventions, safety

guardrails

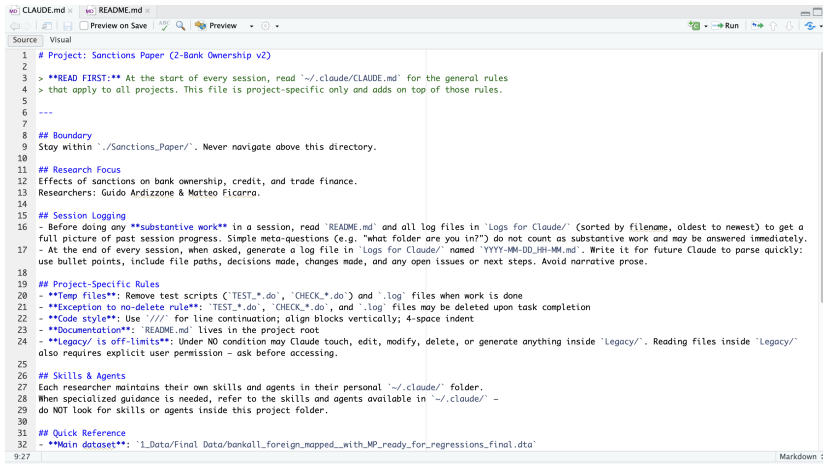
My projects — folders, phases, active datasets

context

The more specific your CLAUDE.md, the less you explain per session.

Example: CLAUDE.md

Located at `~/.claude/CLAUDE.md` — loaded automatically in every session.



```
1 # Project: Sanctions Paper (2-Bank Ownership v2)
2
3 > **READ FIRST:** At the start of every session, read `~/.claude/CLAUDE.md` for the general rules
4 > that apply to all projects. This file is project-specific only and adds on top of those rules.
5
6 ---
7
8 ## Boundary
9 Stay within `./Sanctions_Paper/`. Never navigate above this directory.
10
11 ## Research Focus
12 Effects of sanctions on bank ownership, credit, and trade finance.
13 Researchers: Guido Ardizzone & Matteo Ficarra.
14
15 ## Session Logging
16 - Before doing any **substantive work** in a session, read `README.md` and all log files in `Logs for Claude/` (sorted by filename, oldest to newest) to get a
17 full picture of past session progress. Simple meta-questions (e.g. "what folder are you in?") do not count as substantive work and may be answered immediately.
18 - At the end of every session, when asked, generate a log file in `Logs for Claude/` named `YYYY-MM-DD_HH-MM.md`. Write it for future Claude to parse quickly:
19 use bullet points, include file paths, decisions made, changes made, and any open issues or next steps. Avoid narrative prose.
20
21 ## Project-Specific Rules
22 - **Temp files**: Remove test scripts (`TEST_*.do`, `CHECK_*.do`) and `.log` files when work is done
23 - **Exception to no-delete rule**: `TEST_*.do`, `CHECK_*.do`, and `.log` files may be deleted upon task completion
24 - **Code style**: Use `///` for line continuation; align blocks vertically; 4-space indent
25 - **Documentation**: `README.md` lives in the project root
26 - **Legacy/ is off-limits**: Under NO condition may Claude touch, edit, modify, delete, or generate anything inside `Legacy/`. Reading files inside `Legacy/`
27 also requires explicit user permission - ask before accessing.
28
29 ## Skills & Agents
30 Each researcher maintains their own skills and agents in their personal `~/.claude/` folder.
31 When specialized guidance is needed, refer to the skills and agents available in `~/.claude/` -
32 do NOT look for skills or agents inside this project folder.
33
34 ## Quick Reference
35 - **Main dataset**: `1_Data/Final Data/bankall_foreign_mapped_with_MP_ready_for_regressions_final.dta`
```

README.md gives Claude project-specific context automatically

A README.md in your project folder complements the global CLAUDE.md.

What to put in it

- What the project is about
- Folder structure and key files
- Data sources and how obtained
- Known issues and next steps

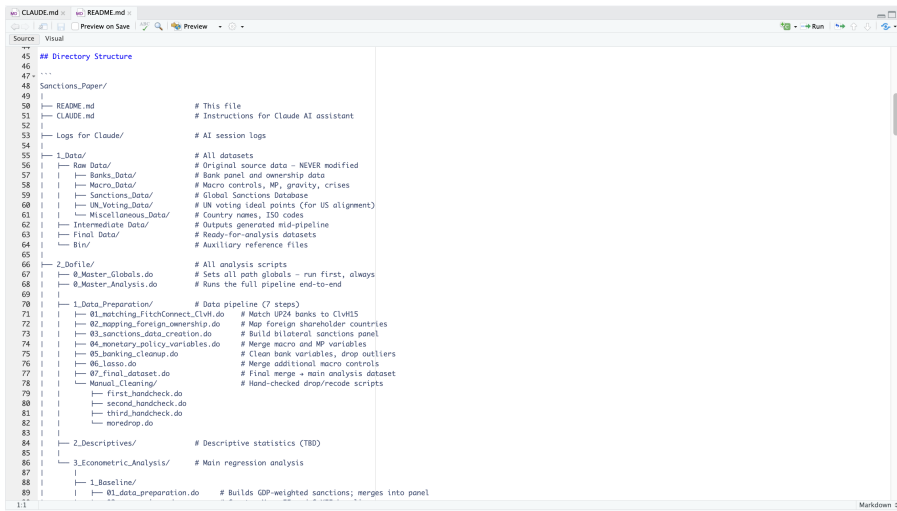
Why it matters

Claude reads it automatically when starting a session in that folder.

No need to re-explain the project each time — even after weeks away.

Have Claude write it for you!

Example: README.md



```
45 ## Directory Structure
46 ...
47
48 Sanctions_Paper/
49 |
50 |   README.md           # This file
51 |   CLAUDE.md           # Instructions for Claude AI assistant
52 |
53 |   Logs for Claude/    # AI session logs
54 |
55 |   1_Data/             # All datasets
56 |   |   Raw Data/       # Original source data - NEVER modified
57 |   |   |   Banks_Data/ # Bank panel and ownership data
58 |   |   |   Macro_Data/ # Macro controls, MP, gravity, crises
59 |   |   |   Sanctions_Data/ # Global Sanctions Database
60 |   |   |   UN_Voting_Data/ # UN voting ideal points (for US alignment)
61 |   |   |   Miscellaneous_Data/ # Country names, ISO codes
62 |   |   |   Intermediate_Data/ # Outputs generated mid-pipeline
63 |   |   |   Final_Data/    # Ready-for-analysis datasets
64 |   |   |   Bln/          # Auxiliary reference files
65 |   |
66 |   2_DoFile/           # All analysis scripts
67 |   |   0_Master_Globals.do # Sets all path globals - run first, always
68 |   |   0_Master_Analysis.do # Runs the full pipeline end-to-end
69 |   |
70 |   |   1_Data_Preparation/ # Data pipeline (7 steps)
71 |   |   |   01_matching_FitchConnect_ClvH.do # Match UP24 banks to ClvH15
72 |   |   |   02_mapping_foreign_ownership.do # Map foreign shareholder countries
73 |   |   |   03_sanctions_data_creation.do # Build bilateral sanctions panel
74 |   |   |   04_monetary_policy_variables.do # Merge macro and MP variables
75 |   |   |   05_banking_cleanup.do # Clean bank variables, drop outliers
76 |   |   |   06_lasso.do # Merge additional macro controls
77 |   |   |   07_final_dataset.do # Final merge + main analysis dataset
78 |   |   |   Manual_Cleaning/ # Hand-checked drop/recode scripts
79 |   |   |   |   First_handcheck.do
80 |   |   |   |   second_handcheck.do
81 |   |   |   |   third_handcheck.do
82 |   |   |   |   noredrop.do
83 |   |
84 |   2_Descriptives/     # Descriptive statistics (T80)
85 |   |
86 |   3_Econometric_Analysis/ # Main regression analysis
87 |   |
88 |   |   1_Baseline/
89 |   |   |   01_data_preparation.do # Builds GDP-weighted sanctions; merges into panel
```

Skills and Agents

Reusable playbooks and parallel workers

Skills are reusable playbooks — invoke once, get consistent behavior

What you type

```
/stata-regression
```

A SKILL.md file in `~/.claude/skills/` that bundles your conventions: estimator, fixed effects, output format, save location.

What Claude does

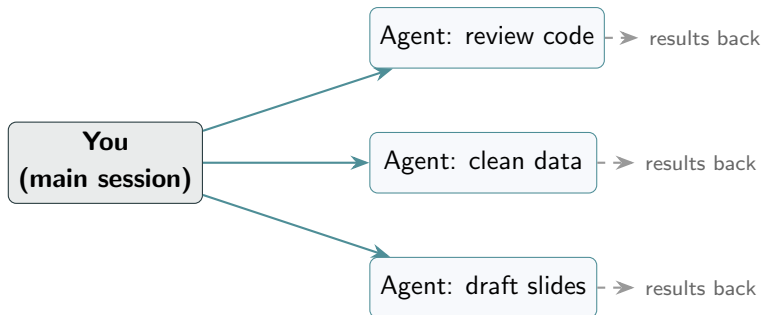
1. Load data per your naming convention
2. Run `reghdfe` with your standard FE
3. Format table with `esttab`
4. Save to `output/tables/`
5. Print diagnostics to terminal

Instead of re-explaining every session, you invoke the skill. Claude starts with full context.

Example: an Extended Abstract Writer Skill

```
extended_abstract_writer (2).md*
Source Visual
23 ---
24
25 ## STEP 1 - GATHER INFORMATION INTERACTIVELY
26
27
28 Ask the user the following questions **one block at a time** - do not dump all
29 questions at once. Wait for the answer to each block before proceeding to the next.
30
31 ### Block 1 - Paper identity
32 Ask:
33 - What is the full title of the paper?
34 - Who are the authors (in order)?
35 - What are the JEL codes, if known? (optional - can be added later)
36
37 ### Block 2 - Purpose and audience
38 Ask:
39 - What is this extended abstract for? Give the user these options and ask them
40 to pick one:
41 1. Conference submission
42 2. Journal submission
43 3. PhD milestone or internal seminar
44 4. Policy / non-academic audience
45
46 - If they answer 1 (conference): also ask for the conference name and submission
47 deadline.
48 - If they answer 2 (journal): also ask for the journal name and any known length
49 or formatting requirements.
50 - If they answer 3 or 4: ask if there are any specific requirements or constraints
51 they want you to keep in mind.
52
53 ### Block 3 - Source files
54 Ask for each of the following, one at a time. For each, if the user says they
55 don't have it or it doesn't exist, note that and move on.
56 {
57 - Where is the paper's main folder? (You will look for README.md and session logs
58 here automatically)
59 - Is there a written draft of the paper (PDF or .tex)? If yes, where is it?
60 If no, note this and continue - the skill can work from slides, figures,
61 and tables alone.
62 - Are there slides? If yes, where?
63 - Are there figures or tables not in a draft - for example regression output,
64 summary statistics, or results figures? If yes, where are they?
65 - Is there an earlier publicly available version of this paper (e.g. a working
66 paper on SSRN or a personal website)? If yes, ask for the URL - it will be
67 added as a \thanks{} footnote on the title page.
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```

Agents work in parallel — you keep thinking while they execute



- Spawns a separate Claude instance
- Runs in its own context window
- Reports results back when done
- Custom .md files = reusable job

Skills guide Claude in *your* conversation.

Agents work *for you* in a separate process.

Agents in Action: Parallel Execution

- Good, the improved prompt is ready. Let me execute it now.

I'll start by running Steps 1-3 in parallel – searching meeting notes, reading the model, and extracting PDFs.

- Running 6 Explore agents... (ctrl+o to expand)
 - Search meeting notes for storage/dynamics · 11 tool uses · 48.5k tokens
 - ↳ Searching for 3 patterns, reading 8 files...
 - Read current model + core papers summary · 29 tool uses · 35.3k tokens
 - ↳ Searching for 6 patterns, reading 23 files...
 - Extract Baffes et al VAR paper · 4 tool uses · 37.4k tokens
 - ↳ Reading 4 files...
 - Extract Couttenier et al gravity of violence · 5 tool uses · 51.8k tokens
 - ↳ Reading 5 files...
 - Extract Boehm lecture slides PDFs · 8 tool uses · 37.2k tokens
 - ↳ Reading 8 files...
 - Extract DEK 2007 paper · 4 tool uses · 49.0k tokens
 - ↳ Reading 4 files...

(ctrl+b to run in background)

* Sautéing... (50s · ↓ 4.6k tokens)

Six **Explore** agents running **simultaneously** — each reading files, searching patterns, and consuming tokens *in parallel*.

Privacy and Confidential Data

Claude has file access — here's how to control it

Three layers protect your confidential data

CLAUDE.md rules (*instructional — followed reliably*)

“NEVER read or modify files in /Raw_Data/” — not enforced, but Claude obeys

PreToolUse hooks (*programmatic*)

Shell scripts that run before any tool call — inspect paths, block with exit code 2

Permission deny rules (*strongest — cannot be overridden*)

"deny": ["Read(/Raw_Data/**)"] in settings.json

Combine all three for defense in depth.

Best Practices

What we've learned so far

Eight practices that make the difference

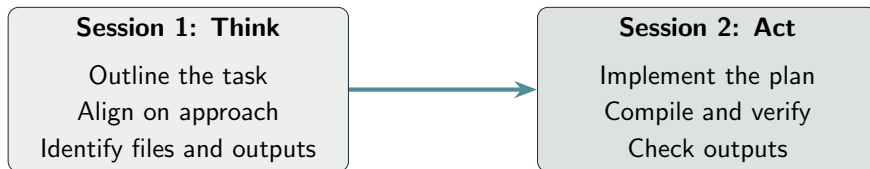
Setup

1. **Write a good CLAUDE.md** — have Claude help you
2. **Set clear boundaries** — protect raw data, review before committing
3. **Use Skills** — reusable playbooks for recurring tasks
4. **Use Git** — Claude handles commits; safe rollbacks

Workflow

5. **No memory** — log files to pick up where you left off
6. **Plan first, act second** — plan in one session, implement in a fresh one
7. **Use Claude to learn Claude** — ask first, understand, then execute
8. **Trust but verify** — always check outputs, especially regressions

Plan in one session, execute in a fresh one

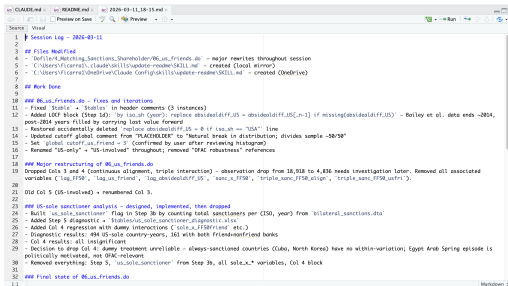


Long threads degrade performance. Fresh context = better output.

Use version control (Git) so every change is reversible.

Log files solve Claude's amnesia

Claude starts every session with a blank memory. **Log files** are the solution.



```
1 Session Log - 2026-03-11
2
3 ## Files Modified
4 - [DiffLock,Matching,Sanctions,ShaneHolder,@us_friends.do] - major rewrites throughout session
5 - [C:\Users\vicarri\ClaudeSkills\update-readme\SKILL.md] - created (local minor)
6 - [C:\Users\vicarri\OneDrive\Claude Config\skills\update-readme\SKILL.md] - created (OneDrive)
7
8 ## Work Done
9
10 ## @us_friends.do - Fixes and iterations
11 - Fixed 'stable' + 'stables' in header comments (3 instances)
12 - Added LDC block (Step 5d): by lca.sh (year); replace obsideidiff_us = obsideidiff_us[n-1] if missing(obsideidiff_us) - Bailey et al. data ends ~2004, post-2004 years filled by carrying last value forward
13 - Restored accidentally deleted 'replace obsideidiff_us = 0 if lca.sh == "USA"' line
14 - Updated cutoff global comment from "PLAZCHOLDER" to "Natural break in distribution; divides sample ~50/50"
15 - See 'global cutoff_us_friend' + 3 (Confirmed by user after reviewing histogram)
16 - Renamed "US-only" + "US-involved" throughout; removed "OFAC robustness" references
17
18 ## Major restructuring of @us_friends.do
19 Dropped cols 3 and 4 (continuous alignment, triple interaction) - observation drop from 18,918 to 4,836 needs investigation later. Removed all associated variables ('lag_pp50', 'lag_us_friend', 'lag_obsideidiff_us', 'sanc_x_pp50', 'triple_sanc_pp50_align', 'triple_sanc_pp50_usfri').
20
21 Old Col 5 (US-involved) + renumbered Col 3.
22
23 ## US-sole sanctions analysis - designed, implemented, then dropped
24 - Built 'us_sole_sanctioner' flag in Step 3b by counting total sanctioners per (ISO, year) from 'bilateral_sanctions.dta'
25 - Added Step 5 diagnostic = $stable(us_sole_sanctioner_diagnostic.xlsx)
26 - Added Col 4 regression with dummy interactions C.sole_x_pp50friend (etc.)
27 - Diagnostic results: 494 US-sole country-years, 161 with both friend/nonfriend banks
28 - Col 4 results: all insignificant
29 - Decision to drop Col 4: dummy treatment unreliable - always-sanctioned countries (Cuba, North Korea) have no within-variation; Egypt Arab Spring episode is politically motivated, not OFAC-relevant
30 - Removed everything: Step 5, 'us_sole_sanctioner' from Step 3b, all sole_x_* variables, Col 4 block
31
32 ## Final state of @us_friends.do
33
```

How it works

1. At end of session, ask Claude to write a log file
2. Name with timestamp
(2026-03-21_15-30.md)
3. Next session: Claude reads logs and picks up where you left off

Live Demo

Seeing it work is worth more than any slide

From a messy prompt to a clean output in real time

Live demonstration

Task to be demonstrated live.

Candidate: clean a dataset, set up a project, or generate a table —
one task, end to end, with the audience watching.

Resources & Community

The ecosystem is growing fast

The community is already building — here's where to find them

People on X

Alex Imas	@alexolegimas
Chris Blattman	@cblatts
David Yanagizawa-Drott	@YanagizawaD
Ethan Mollick	@emollick
Soumitra Shukla	@soumitrashukla9
Kevin Bryan	@Afinetheorem
Andy Hall	@ahall_research
Alexander Kustov	@akoustov
Antonio Mele	@antoniomele101
Anthony Lee Zhang	@alz_zyd_
Aniket Panjwani	@aniketapanjwani
Pedro Sant'Anna	@pedrohcg
Scott Cunningham	@causalinf

Key resources

Panjwani's cohort: ai-mba.io
Blattman's tools: claudefblattman.com
Sant'Anna: github.com/pedrohcg
Skills: github.com/anthropics/skills
Official docs:
docs.anthropic.com/claude-code

Useful Resources

Learning & Training

- Panjwani's cohort: ai-mba.io/cohorts/claude-code-economists
- AI for Econ newsletter: ai-mba.io/newsletter/econ
- Blattman's tools: claudeblattman.com

Skills & Workflows

- Sant'Anna's workflow: github.com/pedrohcg/claude-code-my-workflow
- Skill creator: github.com/anthropics/skills (official)
- Stata setup: ai-mba.io/tutorials/how-to-create-a-stata-skill

Official Docs

- Claude Code: docs.anthropic.com/en/docs/claude-code
- Prompt engineering: docs.anthropic.com/.../prompt-engineering

Using Claude Code as a Department

The profession has changed — let's discuss what to do

Claude Code has changed the profession — the question is how we respond

What we've been discussing

- **Shared repository** — skills, agents, and tools across the department
- **Formal training** — we are not experts; structured learning would help
- **Assessments & courses** — should we change how we teach and evaluate?

Open questions

- **Job market** — fewer entry-level tasks, higher bar for everyone
- **Department resources** — can institutional funds cover access?
- **Other institutions** — what are they doing? What should we do?

It is important not to be left behind — but the jury is still out on whether this is for the better or the worse.

**Claude Code doesn't replace your judgment —
it removes the friction between your judgment and its
execution.**

Questions?

Dario, Guido, Josh, Matteo